

Text: John 11:14-15 “Then said Jesus unto them plainly, Lazarus is dead. ¹⁵And I am glad for your sakes that I was not there, to the intent ye may believe; nevertheless let us go unto him.”

INTRO: We all know the story. . .

- 1.) Lazarus is sick
- 2.) Jesus is late (Just four day's!)
- 3.) Mary and Martha are mad. . . (After all, don't they deserve a little special treatment?)
- 4.) Lazarus is dead. . . (Things are as bad as they can get. This is going to turn out to be Jesus' fault!)

Up until this last turn of events, all Mary Martha and Lazarus needed was a healing, now it was down to a funeral service or a resurrection!

But when you stop and think about it, would it be any more difficult for Jesus to raise the dead than to heal the sick?

The most important event in the history of the world was the **RESURRECTION OF JESUS!** **1 Cor. 15:17** “And if Christ be not raised, your faith is vain; ye are yet in your sins.”

Mary and Martha and those around Jesus have witnessed the sick being healed, but they are about to be taken to **THE NEXT LEVEL. . .** Our churches need to be taken to **THE NEXT LEVEL!!!**

The reason Jesus tarried two more days after hearing the message that Lazarus was sick, is because there was a need for those around him to be taken to **THE NEXT LEVEL!**

They had known Jesus as...

- 1) A Friend...
- 2) A Savior...
- 3) The Master...
- 4) The Healer...
- 5) A Miracle worker...

Notice with me the words of Jesus amidst the mourners in this humble house in Bethany. You would expect him to say something like, **“I’m sorry I did not come when you called for me, I hope this will not affect our friendship!”** Or you would expect him to say, **“I’m sorry I was out of town preaching a meeting, the least I could have done was to come home for the funeral services, I hope you won’t hold this against me at the next Pastoral election!”**

Notice what he said, **“LAZARUS IS DEAD. AND**

I AM GLAD!” Now what kind of a thing is that for Jesus to say?

What he is saying is that **“this whole ordeal is going to turn out for the good, because you are about to see me in a light that you have never seen me in before!”**

Brother and sister don’t ever forget that **“All things work together for good, to those who love God and are called according to his purposes!”**

God is excellent at taking things that Satan meant for evil, and using them to our eternal good!

- 1) Situation at Palestine!
- 2) Being too broke to pay my bills!
- 3) Being too sick to care for myself!
- 4) Fire in the Church at Fouke!

John 11:14-15 “Then said Jesus unto them plainly, **Lazarus is dead. ¹⁵And I am glad for your sakes that I was not there, to the intent ye may believe;**”

The bottom line is, that if Jesus had not delayed, Mary and Martha would not have gotten to know Him at the **LEVEL** of Resurrection power for everyday living!

During the course of this message we have talked extensively about going to **THE NEXT LEVEL**. If

you and I are going to **THE NEXT LEVEL** in God, there must of necessity, be certain things that happen in our lives. These things will happen by the will of God! Let's look at them;

I. GOING TO THE NEXT LEVEL MEANS THAT IT IS NECESSARY FOR SOME THINGS TO DIE!

A. John 12:24 “**Verily, verily, I say unto you, Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone: but if it die, it bringeth forth much fruit.”**

THE DAY I GOT SAVED WAS THE DAY I DIED!

ILL: Jesus said to the Father, “**Don is dead, and I am glad. . .** “

B. Galatians 2:20 “**I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me: and the life which I now live in the flesh I live by the faith of the Son of God, who loved me, and gave himself for me.”**

C. If you are not willing to Die, and allow Christ to live out his life through you, you will never know what it really means to go to **THE NEXT LEVEL!**

II. IT TAKES FAITH TO GO TO THE NEXT LEVEL!

A. As close as Mary, Martha, and Jesus were it took **FAITH** on their part to believe Lazarus could live again! **John 11:20-28** “Then Martha, as soon as she heard that Jesus was coming, went and met him: but Mary sat *still* in the house. ²¹Then said Martha unto Jesus, Lord, if thou hadst been here, my brother had not died. ²²But I know, that even now, whatsoever thou wilt ask of God, God will give it thee. ²³Jesus saith unto her, **Thy brother shall rise again.** ²⁴Martha saith unto him, I know that he shall rise again in the resurrection at the last day. ²⁵Jesus said unto her, **I am the resurrection, and the life: he that believeth in me, though he were dead, yet shall he live: ²⁶And whosoever liveth and believeth in me shall never die. Believest thou this?** ²⁷She saith unto him, Yea, Lord: I believe that thou art the Christ, the Son of God, which should come into the world. ²⁸And when she had so said, she went her way, and called Mary her sister secretly, saying, The Master is come, and calleth for thee.”

B. The man with the withered hand. . . (Luke 6 tells us it was his right hand). . . Jesus said. . . **Luke 6:10** “And looking round about upon them all, he said unto the man, **Stretch forth thy hand.** And he did so: and his hand was restored whole as the other.”

It took **FAITH** for this man to stretch forth his hand!

He could have stretched forth his good hand. . . Jesus was wanting to take him to a **LEVEL** where he had never been. . . **LET'S QUIT STRETCHING FORTH OUR GOOD HAND...**

C. If Mary and Martha would have reacted differently to Jesus there brother might not have received his miracle! (They could have gotten offended and quit the Church!) (They had a perfect opportunity for a pity party!)

I found myself wondering as I prepared for this message, how many times have I short circuited a miracle in my life because I reacted with indifference? How many times have I missed the opportunity to go to **THE NEXT LEVEL** because of a stubborn refusal to miss a grand opportunity at a pity party?

If we are to go to **THE NEXT LEVEL** we must operate in **FAITH** not in self pity!

III. THERE COMES A TIME TO UNCORK THE CAVE IF WE ARE EVER GOING TO THE NEXT LEVEL!

A. John 11:39 “Jesus said, Take ye away the stone. Martha, the sister of him that was dead, saith unto

him, Lord, by this time he stinketh: for he hath been *dead* four days.”

THEY HAD PUT A LID ON THIS THING - We are always trying to keep a lid on things. . .

We want to make sure that things don't get too far out of hand, because sister strait jacket, and brother starched shirt might be embarrassed, or worse yet offended!

B. Jesus comes to the mouth of the cave. Everybody follows Him. There is an air of excitement. Jesus says GET READY! GET READY! GET READY! TAKE YE AWAY THE STONE. . .

Martha, who has to have everything just right says, **“HOLD EVERYTHING! BY THIS TIME HE STINKETH!”**

Now please understand, there is the possibility of a **RESURRECTION** here, Martha is aware of that, and the only thing she can see is, **“We've got a stinking situation here. . .”**

Now please understand, I know about stinking situations...

- 1) Dead dog under the office. . .
- 2) Counseling couples who are at each others throats,

only to have them
both to turn on you...

3) Help a friend get in business, only to get double crossed...

Don't try to tell me about stinking situations, I helped to edit the book on it! But for every stinking Situation, there is always an opportunity for a **RESURRECTION!**

If you ever hope to go to **THE NEXT LEVEL**, somewhere some time you must become willing to **UNCORK THE CAVE! ROLL THE STONE AWAY! TAKE THE LID OFF!**

ILL: Jesus is standing outside of your life, right in the big middle of your stinking situation and he is urging you, **UNCORK THE CAVE! ROLL THE STONE AWAY! TAKE THE LID OFF! GET READY! GET READY! GET READY!**

C. THE STINK DIDN'T STOP JESUS THEN, AND IT WON'T STOP HIM NOW...

ILL: Do you feel that Ichabod has been written over your life? . . . The glory has departed? . . . **ISRAEL IS DEAD?...** But look down the road, I see David bringing the ark back into Jerusalem dancing. . .

ILL: We don't need **REVITALIZATION** - We need a **RESURRECTION!**

To revitalize means. . .

- 1.) To nourish
- 2.) To comfort
- 3.) To revive
- 4.) To gratify
- 5.) To cheer
- 6.) To bolster
- 7.) To pamper

That is like taking a can of air freshener and spraying it into the cave. .

CONCLUSION: Jesus said, **“ROLL THE STONE AWAY!” “LAZARUS COME FORTH!”**

Now this is exciting because when Jesus said this Lazarus' spirit came back into him. . . and he lived. . .

WHAT IS MORE EXCITING. . . JESUS DIED - AND I AM GLAD. . .

Mary Magdalene and the other Mary came to the tomb. . . **WHO WILL ROLL AWAY THE STONE?**
An angel descended and rolled away the stone. . .

Here is what excites me. When I died at that altar and the stone was rolled away, God's Holy Spirit raised me up. . . **Romans 8:11** **“But if the Spirit of him that raised up Jesus from the dead dwell in you, he that raised up Christ from the dead shall also quicken your mortal bodies by his Spirit that dwelleth in you.”**